Checklist for Evaluating SEO Donor Trust Criteria
Short Report
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Abstract
This document provides a structured framework for evaluating the trustworthiness and quality of web platforms used for external link placement in search engine optimization (SEO) campaigns. The criteria outlined below are designed to help SEO practitioners and digital marketers assess potential donor sites before committing resources to link building activities.

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1. Introduction
Link building remains a fundamental component of search engine optimization strategies. However, the effectiveness of link placement depends heavily on the quality and trustworthiness of donor platforms. Poor quality links can negatively impact search rankings, while high-quality links from trusted sources can significantly improve visibility.
This checklist presents five key criteria for manual evaluation of potential donor sites, based on industry best practices and empirical observations from link building campaigns.

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2. Evaluation Criteria
2.1 Indexing Status
The donor page must be present in the main search engine index. Before placement, verify that the page appears in search results for relevant queries. Pages that are not indexed cannot pass link equity and represent wasted resources.
Verification method: Search for the page URL or unique content fragments in Google using the "site:" operator.
2.2 Domain Trust and History
Established domains with consistent history demonstrate higher trust signals to search engines. Evaluate:

- Domain age (older domains generally carry more weight)
- Historical traffic patterns (stable or growing traffic indicates legitimate operation)
- Spam score metrics (avoid domains with sudden spikes in spam indicators)
- Backlink profile quality (natural link growth patterns)

2.3 Link Openness and Technical Accessibility
Links must be technically accessible to search engine crawlers:

- No redirect chains (direct links preferred)
- No "nofollow" or "sponsored" attributes unless specifically required
- No JavaScript-based link rendering that may prevent crawling

- Proper HTML structure with standard anchor tags

2.4 Manual Moderation and Quality Control
Platforms with manual content moderation typically maintain higher quality standards:

- Editorial review process for submitted content
- Human oversight of link placements
- Clear content guidelines and quality standards
- Responsive support for content issues

Automated platforms with no moderation often accumulate low-quality content, reducing the value of links placed there.
2.5 Contextual Relevance
The thematic alignment between the donor page content and the linked resource affects link value:

- Topical relevance between donor page and target content
- Logical placement within related content
- Natural anchor text integration
- Consistent thematic focus of the donor site

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3. Implementation Notes
These criteria should be applied systematically before each link placement. A scoring system can be developed to quantify donor quality:

- High trust (80-100 points): Meets all five criteria, suitable for priority placements
- Medium trust (50-79 points): Meets most criteria, acceptable for standard campaigns
- Low trust (below 50 points): Fails multiple criteria, avoid for link building

Regular re-evaluation is recommended, as donor site quality can change over time due to ownership changes, content strategy shifts, or algorithm updates.

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4. Conclusion
Systematic evaluation of donor trust criteria helps optimize link building budgets and improves campaign outcomes. By applying these five criteria consistently, SEO practitioners can build sustainable link profiles that support long-term search visibility goals.

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Additional Materials
Extended evaluation methodology, detailed scoring templates, and comprehensive donor database are available open-source at: https://newsens.ru/

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